

IN PROFILE

Wilhelm Hensel

Although his work is little known today, Fanny's husband, Wilhelm Hensel, had a fairly successful career as an artist. In 1829, he was appointed court painter by Frederick William III of Prussia. He was best known in his lifetime as a portraitist, but he also produced religious and historical pictures. Hensel had no particular interest in music, but he was devoted to Fanny, had great respect for her talents, and was hugely supportive of her career and ambitions. Her sudden death was a devastating blow from which he never fully recovered.



WILHELM HENSEL, SELF-PORTRAIT, 1829

Fanny Mendelssohn was born in Hamburg, the eldest of four children of a wealthy, cultivated family. She enjoyed the same privileged upbringing as her brother Felix, with the best tutors available in every subject. Like Felix, she was intellectually accomplished and her talent